



THERE'S NO REASON WE CAN'T DO THESE THINGS IN INDIA

Pratyush Kumar and Vivek Raghavan, co-founders, Sarvam AI, talk to BT Group Editor Siddharth Zarabi about how they defied the naysayers and plans to monetise the foundation model. Edited excerpts



Pratyush Kumar, co-founder, Sarvam AI

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How does it feel to beat the odds?

Kumar: It's the team that has built something with a lot of passion. There's a lot that India is doing in using AI in enterprises, for people, and so on. Because if we are in the post-AI world—we're never going to go back to pre-LLMs (large language models)—as such an important country, we cannot not have our own laboratory with such an important technology. India should build its own thing.

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Is this moment comparable to what global technology giants have achieved, given that they have invested billions of dollars to reach where they are today?

Raghavan: What's important to understand is the perception that

breakthroughs like this can happen only in Silicon Valley or China. That's the mindset we need to change. There's no reason we can't do these things in India.

We are still at the beginning of this journey. The intent behind starting Sarvam was simple: can we build a truly large technology company out of India? This technology is so fundamental that it shapes everything that follows.

I don't want to diminish the fact that companies which have invested hundreds of billions of dollars in solving these problems are clearly ahead of where we are today. But the key point is this: we believe we can belong in that league. I don't think we would have been able to build this model without support from the India AI Mission. While it

may not technically be a grant, the support we received—access to compute at concessional rates and an equity-based structure instead of having to pay the full amount in cash—was critical.

The costs we have incurred are significantly lower. We're talking about funding in the range of \$25–30 million. It's fair to say we have been efficient. At the same time, with greater resources, we can achieve much more.

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When someone as prominent as Sam Altman, the CEO of OpenAI, suggested that India perhaps shouldn't even attempt this, it sparked a broader debate, especially given the stereotype that Indians are known more for jugaad than for building foundational technology.

Kumar: I think there are two sides to the issue of frugality.

Jugaad is thought of as a hack—not doing the right thing, finding a workaround. The other thing is being resource-efficient. We have managed to create significantly useful models with significantly lower resources. Notice that we did two things. One, we did the hard work ourselves. Second, in the last two years, the technology has become so much better that the cost of building these models has reduced. We are in a deflationary world of AI. So, in that sense, the memes around "only a couple of companies will build LLMs for the whole world," they are not there anymore. In fact, at the AI Summit, French President Emmanuel Macron and Prime Minister Narendra Modi said we have to build AI together.